Nationalities League for Democracy (SNLD). Thus, together with the members of parliament appointed from the military, the USDP has the ability to form a working majority in the Shan State Hluttaw.[3]

The challenges for the incoming government are vast. They include continued economic liberalization, democratic reforms, continuation of the peace process, the necessary balance of power with the military, and hardly any experience in governance. Challenges also come from the overwhelming NLD victory itself: how will the victor engage with the less successful in the future? Very few parties that decided against a boycott in 2010, as the NLD and its allies did, won seats five years later. While a diversity of ethnic representation continues to exist in parliament, most members are from the NLD. As the Transnational Institute (TNI 2015, p. 12) notes, "Ethnic-based parties, in contrast, hold few seats which is reminiscent of Myanmar's post-independence democratic period." Ahead lies an unscripted future, including the resolution of major conflicts, which were prominent throughout the electoral process. However, all sides, including the military, have made reconciliatory signals in the early post-election period.

THE NEXUS OF ELECTIONS AND CONFLICT

As a point of departure, this chapter suggests that elections are rarely the root cause of conflict, but have the potential to exacerbate pre-existing levels of conflict. Further, the angle on conflict taken here is wider than a mere focus on electoral violence occurring during the campaign period, on election day, or in its immediate aftermath, which is usually defined by its intentional character (for example, Höglund 2009). The analysis of conflict and its entanglements with the electoral process should not be limited to a focus on escalation of physical violence, but also extend to forms of structural violence and disenfranchisement, although mitigation strategies derived from such an analysis should aim to minimize the risks of physical harm.

Practitioner communities supporting elections internationally increasingly view elections as cyclical (Tuccinardi et al. 2007). This allows their analysis over a longer time frame and takes the preparations and organization of the ballot into account. The longer periods of the electoral cycle are less visible to the public eye and grow in intensity as election day approaches.